

Athena's Little Owl

The sunlit hills of Greece roll down to a bright blue sea, dotted with olive groves, white marble columns, and little towns where everyone knows your name. High above, hidden in the clouds of Mount Olympus, the gods watch over the world, and the hills are full of wonders: riddling sphinxes, kindly centaurs, shy satyrs, and nymphs who sing by the springs. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a cool head, asks good questions, and stands by a friend. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas. Even a fearsome guardian, met with courage and a fair word, often turns out to be lonelier than it is wicked.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only kinder ideas to try.*

Before you begin

The fog came down over the hills before dawn, soft and grey and thick as wool, and with it came a small, lost sound: the frightened hoot of an owl. When the Olive Town woke, there in the middle of the square sat a tiny owl, her feathers ruffled and her round eyes wide. Her name was Glaux, and she was the companion of kind Athena, whose temple stood high on the hill of white marble. In the fog she had lost her way, and she could not find the road home.

Old Daphne, keeper of the olive grove, called the two of you to her side. "You have sharp eyes and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more this morning than the fastest pair of legs in Greece. Will you guide little Glaux safely back up to Athena?"

Gently she wrapped the owl in a soft scarf and placed her in your care. "Remember," she said, "up here we do not help by being the biggest or the boldest. We help by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Heart?*

Stop 1 The Foggy Square

Glaux huddled in the heart of the square, so small that the cobblestones seemed huge around her. Her feathers stood on end, her round eyes blinked and blinked, and each time a foot scuffed too near she startled and hopped away. She was far too frightened to be carried anywhere yet.

★ *How could you help her feel safe before you set out? Might you move slowly and keep your voices soft? Might you hold out a steady hand and simply wait for her to choose you? What do you try?*

When you grew calm and gentle and let her come to you in her own time, Glaux stopped her trembling. She studied you with those round amber eyes, gave a small contented hoot, and hopped up onto your waiting hand. From that moment she trusted you completely.

Stop 2 The Whispering Paths

Where the town ended, three narrow paths wound up into the mist, and in the grey half-light each looked exactly like the others. Only one of them climbed to Athena's temple; the other two would lead you in circles until the day was gone.

A goat-legged satyr swung himself up onto a wall, grinning through the fog. It was Bramble, who loved a traveller and a good joke in equal measure, and who was always glad to point the way for heroes he liked.



How will you choose the right path? Look closely at the ground. As Glaux tumbled down in the night she shed soft grey feathers along the way. Could you follow that trail back up? Could you ask cheerful Bramble for a hint? What is your plan?

By following the scattered feathers, or by asking kind Bramble for his help, you found the one true path, and you began to climb together through the drifting mist.

Stop 3 The High Perch

At the summit stood a small temple of white marble, its columns rising into the last of the fog. High among them was Glaux's perch, a snug hollow where she slept each night. But the little owl was weary now, and frightened, and the mist still hid her roost. She did not dare make the flight alone.



This was never about being strong. How might you help her up? Could you lift a steady branch to make a bridge for her small feet? Could you cheer her on, so that she found her courage? What do you do?

When you helped her with patience and kindness, Glaux gathered herself, spread her small wings, and fluttered up to her perch at last. There she settled into the warm hollow, safe and snug, and tucked her head beneath one wing.

Glaux Comes Home

As the owl nestled down, two calm grey eyes opened within the temple, bright as polished silver. It was Athena herself, goddess of good ideas and kindness, and she was smiling down at the two of you.

At her smile the morning fog began to lift, thinning and curling and floating away, until the sun broke through and poured golden light across the Olive Town far below. From her high perch Glaux gave one clear, happy hoot, as if to say thank you.

You had done it, and you had done it together: with your ideas, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Sunlit Hills.

Athena's Little Owl: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle, kindly tale, and no one in it is ever truly hurt or frightened for long.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Olive Town.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out a prop or two if you can: anything small and soft to stand in for Glaux the owl, and a feather or a scrap of paper or two for her trail. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Heart together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these hills, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	A friendly satyr gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A favourable wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Chiron the centaur passes by and nods kindly. All is well.
5	An olive branch for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only a small lost owl and the kindness it takes to bring her home. The adventure is won by helping Glaux feel safe, choosing the true path with sharp eyes, and giving the tired little owl a gentle hand up to her perch. Let the children lead with care; that is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Athena's Little Owl: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward fresh ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Foggy Square (Easy)

The challenge. Glaux the owl is too frightened to be carried. The players must help her feel safe enough to trust them and hop onto a waiting hand.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Observation moment. The kind move is to slow right down: lower their voices, move gently, hold still, and let the owl come to them rather than grabbing for her. Holding out a steady hand and waiting works beautifully.

Fallback. If the children rush and Glaux hops away, have Daphne hum a soft tune, or let a player spend an energy star to sit quietly until the owl creeps closer. Any gentle idea wins her trust and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: The Whispering Paths (Normal)

The challenge. Three paths climb into the fog and all look the same. The players must find the one that leads to Athena's temple.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Logic moment. The good idea is to look down and follow the trail of soft grey feathers Glaux shed as she fell. Asking **Bramble the Satyr** for a hint, or letting the owl herself turn her head toward home, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Bramble pop up and point the way with a joke, or let them spend an energy star to spot the feathers in the mist. Getting through with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The High Perch (Normal)

The challenge. Glaux is tired and afraid to fly the last stretch up to her high marble perch through the mist. The players must help her up.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Spatial moment. Any kind, gentle idea works: lifting a steady branch to bridge the gap, making a careful step for her small feet, or simply cheering her on until she finds the courage to flutter up. There is no wrong way to be kind here.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have Glaux give a small, hopeful hoot and lean toward them, and let a single encouraging word be enough. The moment they offer help of any kind, the little owl reaches her perch.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When Glaux is safely home, kind **Athena** opens her calm grey eyes, the morning fog lifts, and the sun pours warm and golden over the **Olive Town**. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.